

Dr Victoria Froome

**SUPPORTING YOUR CHILD
THROUGH UNIVERSITY:**
**A Parent's Guide to Mental Health,
Wellbeing and the Transition
Away from Home**



A Dragonfly Handbook®

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Newly Updated For 2026

Dr Victoria Froome

www.dragonflypsychotherapy.co.uk

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This handbook contains tables and structured exercises. In its digital version, their appearance may vary slightly depending on the device, screen size, or font settings used to view the ebook, but all content remains the same.

Important Information

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Contact a healthcare professional or your GP

In the UK:

Call 999 in an emergency,

111 for urgent medical advice,

Samaritans: 116 123 for confidential 24/7 support.

Part One



Understanding The Transition



Welcome And How To Use This Guide

I have written this guide because the transition to university is a family event, not just an individual one. While there is growing recognition that students need mental health support during this period, far less attention is given to what parents and families experience. Your adjustment matters too, and it deserves more than the platitudes about empty nests and newfound freedom that are often all that is on offer.

This guide is designed as a companion to the student version, *Starting University? A Guide for Students: Here's What Your Mental Health Needs You to Know*. You do not need to have read the student guide to use this one, but having both allows for shared language and understanding between you and your young person.

Use this guide in whatever way serves you. If your child has just left and you are struggling, start with Part Four on managing your own transition. If you are worried about their mental health, Part Three on practical support strategies will be most relevant. If communication has become difficult, Part Two offers frameworks for staying connected without overstepping. The worksheets in Part Five can be used whenever you need structured reflection.

This guide operates from several principles. First, your emotions about this transition are valid and deserve support. Second, stepping back does not mean stepping away. Third, your child's struggles do not reflect your parenting. And fourth, this adjustment is temporary, even when it does not feel like it.



Your Changing Role As A Parent

The transition to university marks one of the most significant shifts in the parent-child relationship. After eighteen or more years of daily involvement, protection, and guidance, you are suddenly expected to step back and watch from a distance. This is not just challenging for your child - it is a profound adjustment for you too.

Your role does not disappear; it transforms. You are moving from manager to consultant, from daily caregiver to distant supporter, from primary influence to one voice among many. This shift can trigger unexpected emotions: grief for the child who no longer needs you in the same way, fear about their ability to cope, guilt about things left unsaid or undone, and perhaps relief mixed with sadness about your newfound freedom.

Research shows that parents often experience what psychologists call “ambiguous loss” - your child is still alive and part of your life, but the relationship you knew has fundamentally changed. This can be as challenging as any bereavement, yet it is rarely acknowledged or supported.

What This Transition Really Means

Your protective instincts remain strong, but your ability to act on them is limited. You will know less about their daily life than you have since they were born. They will make decisions you disagree with, and you will not be able to prevent them. Your relationship will eventually become richer and more mutual, but the path there is bumpy.

The paradox at the heart of this transition is that the better you have parented, the more capable your child is of leaving you. Their readiness to go is evidence of your success, not a rejection of your love. Understanding this intellectually is much easier than feeling it emotionally.

If Your Young Person Is Neurodivergent

If your child has autism, ADHD, dyslexia, or any other form of neurodivergence, this transition carries specific additional complexities for you as a parent. You may have spent years advocating for their needs, navigating systems on their behalf, providing the structure and scaffolding that helped them succeed. The prospect of stepping back from that role can feel terrifying - not because you do not trust them, but

because you know how hard they have had to work and how much the environment matters to their wellbeing.

You may worry about sensory overwhelm in halls of residence, about whether they will manage their medication or routines independently, about social dynamics they may struggle to read, or about whether they will access the support they need without you to push for it. These concerns are not overprotective - they reflect genuine understanding of your child's needs.

The adjustment required is to shift from doing things for them to ensuring the structures are in place for them to do things themselves. This might mean helping them connect with disability services before they arrive, supporting their DSA application, and then - and this is the hard part - trusting the systems and trusting your child to navigate them.

Your child may surprise you. Many neurodivergent young people thrive at university in ways they never did at school, precisely because the environment allows more autonomy, more control over their schedule, and more acceptance of difference. Your job now is to be the safety net, not the scaffold.

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What Your Young Person Is Experiencing

Understanding what your child faces at university can help you provide appropriate support. The companion student guide outlines the intensity of simultaneous changes in detail, but here is a summary with guidance on what each phase means for you as a parent.

The Typical Emotional Journey

Before arrival: Your child may oscillate between excitement and terror. They might pick fights with you as a way of making leaving easier, or become uncharacteristically clingy. Family dynamics can become strained as everyone processes the upcoming separation differently. Try not to take the conflict personally - it is often a form of emotional preparation for departure.

Weeks 1-2 (honeymoon phase): You might not hear much from them during this period. They are caught up in the intensity of freshers' week, saying yes to everything, overwhelmed by novelty. The lack of contact can be anxiety-provoking for you, but silence during this period usually means they are engaged, not struggling.

Weeks 3-8 (reality phase): This is when you are most likely to receive distressed phone calls. The novelty has worn off, academic pressure has begun, and homesickness hits hard. They may cry, express regret about going, or ask to come home. This is the most challenging period for parents, because your instinct is to rescue them and yet the most helpful response is usually to listen, validate, and encourage them to access university support.

Months 2-4 (finding their rhythm): Things gradually improve. They develop routines, form real friendships, and begin to feel at home. You might notice them calling less often - which is a positive sign, not a rejection. They are building a life that does not revolve around you, and that is exactly what should be happening.

End of first term and return home: Their return can be surprisingly difficult. They have changed, and so has the household. They may resist house rules, seem distant, or struggle to fit back into their old life. You might feel hurt by how different they seem or how quickly they want to return to university. They may seem to want to spend more time catching up with school friends than with you. This displacement is normal - they are now a person of two worlds.

Your child might not share their struggles with you. This is not necessarily rejection - they might be protecting you from worry, asserting independence, or simply overwhelmed. The cheerful phone calls might mask loneliness, the “everything’s fine” texts might hide academic struggles, and the social media posts showing parties might not reveal the anxiety underneath.

What Neurodivergent Students Specifically Face

If your child is neurodivergent, certain aspects of the transition may be more intense. Freshers’ week can cause sensory overload and social exhaustion. The loss of familiar routines can destabilise executive function. Shared living spaces present sensory challenges that are not trivial but genuinely disabling. Social demands can lead to masking fatigue and eventual burnout.

Neurodivergent burnout - a state of physical, emotional, and cognitive exhaustion - can look like depression but has different causes and needs different responses. If your child seems to have “lost skills” they previously had, seems more sensitive to stimuli, or has withdrawn significantly, burnout may be a factor. Recovery requires reduced demands and genuine rest, not encouragement to push through.

The good news is that many neurodivergent students eventually find university suits them better than school. The greater autonomy, the ability to pursue deep interests, and a more accepting social environment can be genuinely liberating. The transition period is the hardest part.

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Common Parent Challenges

The Information Vacuum

After years of knowing their schedule, friends, and daily experiences, you suddenly know only what they choose to share. This information vacuum can trigger anxiety and imagination spirals about worst-case scenarios. You might find yourself checking their social media for clues, reading into the tone of brief text messages, or catastrophising when they do not respond for hours.

This loss of information is one of the most difficult aspects of the transition for parents. It helps to recognise that the anxiety you feel is proportional to the abruptness of the change, not to the actual level of risk. Your child is statistically safe, even when your imagination tells you otherwise.

The Comparison Trap

Other parents seem to have children who call daily, achieve firsts, and seamlessly adjust. Social media amplifies this, showing only success stories. University parent Facebook groups can be particularly triggering, with posts about achievements, visits, and close relationships that may not reflect your experience. Remember: every family struggles with this transition, but few discuss it openly.

Role Confusion

When should you intervene? When should you step back? The boundaries are unclear and constantly shifting. You might oscillate between over-involvement and artificial distance, unsure where healthy support lies. A call about a flat mate dispute: do you advise, listen, or suggest they handle it? A low exam mark: do you contact the university, help them find support, or say nothing unless asked? There are no universal right answers - but the general direction is toward listening more and solving less.

Financial Strain And Guilt

University costs can strain family finances significantly. You might feel guilty about not providing more, resentful about sacrifices made, or anxious about debt accumulating. The cost-of-living crisis has intensified financial

pressures on students, and research shows that the majority of students report financial worries affecting their mental health. These feelings are valid and common.

When Your Child Is Neurodivergent

If your child is neurodivergent, you face additional challenges specific to this experience. You may grieve the loss of your advocacy role - the years spent fighting for their needs at school, attending meetings, pushing for accommodations. This work was a significant part of your identity, and it does not end overnight, but it must transform. You are moving from being their advocate to supporting them in becoming their own advocate.

You may also carry more anxiety than other parents because you know, from experience, that systems do not always work for neurodivergent people. The fear that they will not receive appropriate support, that staff will not understand their needs, or that they will mask until they crash is not unfounded. But you cannot prevent every difficulty - and some of their most important learning will come from navigating challenges themselves, with your support available in the background.

Part Two



Communication And Connection



Maintaining Healthy Communication

Communication patterns that worked for eighteen years might suddenly fail. Your daily “How was school?” becomes weekly “How’s uni?” met with monosyllabic responses. This is not necessarily rejection - it is part of individuation.

Effective Communication Strategies

Timing matters. Ask when they prefer to talk rather than calling randomly. Respect that they might not answer immediately. Evening calls might catch them social planning; afternoon might work better. Sunday afternoons often work well for longer conversations. Avoid calling during freshers’ week events or exam periods unless they initiate.

Quality over quantity. One meaningful weekly conversation trumps daily checking in. Focus on listening rather than interrogating. Share your own life updates - make it a two-way conversation. Avoid making every conversation about university. Ask open questions: “What’s been interesting this week?” rather than “Have you been to lectures?”

Digital balance. Text for quick check-ins: “Thinking of you” rather than “Are you okay?” - the latter implies you think they should not be okay. Video calls for important conversations. Voice notes can feel less intrusive than calls. Respect if they do not follow you on social media - this is boundary-setting, not rejection.

Conversation Approaches That Work

“I’m here if you want to talk” rather than “You never tell me anything.” “How are you finding things?” rather than specific interrogation. “That sounds challenging” rather than immediately offering solutions. “What support do you need?” rather than assuming what would help. “I trust you to handle this, and I’m here if you want to think it through together” rather than jumping to fix it.

If Your Young Person Is Neurodivergent

Communication with neurodivergent young people at university may need specific adjustments. Some may prefer texting to phone calls. Some may find open-ended questions overwhelming and respond better to specific ones. Some may share information in bursts rather than in regular updates. Some may become less

communicative when they are struggling, not more - which makes it harder to know when to be concerned.

If your child has always relied on you to help process experiences, they may initially struggle without that support. You can offer to be a sounding board by text or phone, while gradually encouraging them to use university support services for the same purpose.



Setting Boundaries Together

Boundaries are not walls; they are agreements that allow healthy relationships to flourish. Negotiating these with your university student requires delicacy and mutual respect.

Communication Boundaries

Agree on contact frequency that works for both. Establish emergency versus non-emergency communication. Respect their need for space while expressing your need for connection. Be clear about what information you need (safety) versus want (details). Frame agreements positively: “Let’s agree on a Sunday call” rather than “You never ring me.”

Financial Boundaries

Clear agreements about what you will fund and what they will cover. Whether financial support comes with conditions - and being honest about those conditions rather than leaving them unspoken. How much information about spending you require. Emergency fund access and conditions. These conversations are best had before they leave, but can be revisited at any point.

Academic Boundaries

Whether you will have access to grades. How much involvement in course choices. Your role (if any) in academic difficulty. Respecting their chosen field even if you disagree. Universities will not share academic information with parents without the student’s consent - this is appropriate, even when it feels frustrating.

Visit Boundaries

How often you will visit them - and how much notice is required. Whether surprise visits are acceptable (they rarely are). Their visits home - frequency and duration. Being realistic about how home visits will feel - they may want to see friends, sleep, and recharge rather than spend every moment with family.



Crisis Recognition And Response

Distinguishing between normal adjustment and serious concern requires careful attention. Your parental instincts remain valuable, but they need calibration for distance support.

Normal Adjustment Signs

These include: homesickness that comes in waves, occasional academic struggles, social ups and downs, sleep pattern changes, mood fluctuations, financial management mistakes, and questioning course choice. These are all part of normal transition and generally resolve over time with support.

Concerning Signs Requiring Action

Watch for: communication completely stopping (beyond normal reduction), dramatic personality changes, mentions of self-harm or suicide (even if seemingly joking), substance use as primary coping, complete academic disengagement, extreme weight changes, paranoia or disconnection from reality, or expressions of hopelessness or worthlessness that persist.

How To Respond To Crisis

Stay calm - your anxiety will not help them. Listen without judgement. Avoid minimising (“Everyone feels that way”) or catastrophising. If you are concerned about self harm, ask directly - asking does not plant the idea, and direct questions can save lives. Connect them with professional support. Consider visiting if seriously worried. Contact university support services if your child is unable to do so themselves.

If your child discloses a new mental health condition or a new neurodivergent diagnosis at university (this is increasingly common), try to receive the information with openness. They may have been processing this for some time before telling you. Your reaction will significantly affect whether they continue to share with you.

Crisis Resources For Parents

Samaritans: 116 123 (for you or them, 24/7).

PAPYRUS HOPELINE247: 0800 068 4141, 24/7 (for those under 35 and anyone concerned about a young person). Also text HOPE to 88247.

Young Minds Parents Helpline: 0808 802 5544 (Mon-Fri, 9:30am-4pm Mon/Thu/Fri, 9:30am-6pm Tue/Wed).

Shout: Text SHOUT to 85258 (24/7 text support).

NHS: 111, then select the mental health option.

Your child's university wellbeing services.

GP services near the university.

University emergency/security numbers.

Part Three



Practical Support Strategies

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Financial Conversations And Support

Money conversations combine practical necessity with emotional complexity. Your financial support might come with unspoken expectations, while their financial independence might feel like rejection.

Creating Healthy Financial Dialogue

Be transparent about what you can afford. Discuss expectations tied to financial support. Acknowledge if financial strain affects the family. Separate financial support from emotional control - money should not be a lever for maintaining influence over their choices.

Practical Approaches

Consider whether a monthly allowance or emergency-only support works better for your family. Teach budgeting without micromanaging - help them set up a system, then step back. Plan for a gradual increase in financial independence over the university years. Have a clear agreement about who pays for what, including accommodation, food, travel, course materials, and social spending.

Disabled Students' Allowance

If your child is neurodivergent or has a disability, Disabled Students' Allowance (DSA) is a government-funded support that does not need to be repaid. It can cover specialist mentoring, assistive technology, and study skills support. The application goes through Student Finance and requires a needs assessment.

Help your child apply early - the process can take several weeks, and having support in place from the start makes a significant difference.

When Financial Crisis Hits

Avoid immediate rescue - discuss solutions together. Help them access university hardship funds. Teach consequence while preventing disaster. Consider whether loans versus gifts are appropriate for your situation.

Remember that financial stress is one of the biggest contributors to student mental health problems, so taking it seriously is not indulgent.



Academic And Social Challenges

When your child struggles academically or socially, your instinct might be to intervene directly. However, university requires different support approaches from school.

Supporting Academic Challenges

Encourage use of university support services rather than solving problems yourself. Help them draft emails to professors if they are struggling to communicate, but do not send the emails for them. Discuss study strategies without taking over. Normalise struggle as part of learning - the transition from school to university-level work is genuinely difficult, and most students find it hard initially. Avoid grade fixation; focus on learning and wellbeing.

Supporting Social Difficulties

Validate loneliness as normal - research shows that a third of students feel lonely most of the time. Suggest joining societies without forcing. Share your own social struggle stories if you have them. Avoid “In my day” comparisons, which rarely land well. Resist the urge to arrange friendships for them.

For neurodivergent students, social difficulties may be long-standing and complex. Avoid suggesting they “just put themselves out there” - the social demands of university can be genuinely overwhelming for someone who processes social information differently. Instead, help them identify contexts where social connection might feel more manageable: societies with shared interests, smaller groups, structured activities, or online communities.

Navigating AI And Academic Integrity

Your child may talk to you about AI tools in their academic work, and you may have strong opinions about this. University policies on AI use vary significantly and are still evolving. Rather than imposing your views, encourage them to understand their specific university and course policies. The academic integrity landscape has genuinely changed, and the rules are different. Trust them to navigate this with guidance from their lecturers.

When They Want To Quit

This is one of the most challenging moments for a parent. Listen to understand, not to convince. Explore what is really driving the desire - is it a specific problem that could be resolved, or a fundamental mismatch? Discuss alternatives and consequences without catastrophising. Support their decision-making process rather than making the decision for them. Remember: leaving university does not equal failure, and staying at all costs does not equal success.



Supporting Mental Health From A Distance

Supporting your child's mental health from afar requires balancing concern with respect for their autonomy. This is perhaps the area where parents feel most helpless, and it deserves careful attention.

Preventive Approaches

Normalise mental health discussions early - ideally before they leave for university. Share your own mental health strategies if you are comfortable doing so. Encourage registration with a university GP as one of their first tasks. Frame counselling as health maintenance, not crisis response - the same way you might suggest regular exercise rather than waiting for a health scare. Send care packages during stressful periods; these communicate love without demanding interaction.

When Concerns Arise

Express observations without diagnosis: "You seem different lately" rather than "I think you're depressed." Encourage professional support without ultimatums. Share resources without overwhelming - one or two specific suggestions are more helpful than a list of twenty. Maintain regular contact without it becoming surveillance. Consider family therapy if relationship strain emerges during this period.

Understanding University Mental Health Services

University counselling services typically offer a limited number of sessions, which varies by institution, and may have waiting lists. They are not equivalent to long-term therapy. For students with more complex needs, the university should help facilitate NHS referrals. Students can also self-refer to NHS Talking Therapies for free treatment of common conditions like anxiety and depression.

Working With University Services

Understand that confidentiality boundaries mean the university generally cannot share information about your child without their consent. This can be frustrating, especially if you are worried, but it exists to protect your child's autonomy and their willingness to seek help. You can, however, share your concerns with the university - they may not be able to tell you anything, but they can listen to what you tell them and act on it.

Build a relationship with their personal tutor if possible. Know the wellbeing service contact details. Understand fitness-to-study procedures so you know what to expect if your child's mental health significantly affects their ability to continue their course.

If Your Young Person Has A Pre-Existing Mental Health Condition

If your child already has a mental health diagnosis, the transition to university requires specific planning. Ensure continuity of care by arranging GP registration, medication prescriptions, and any specialist referrals before they leave. Share relevant information with the university disability service (with your child's consent). Discuss a plan for what happens if they become unwell - who they will contact, what your role will be, and what the university can offer.

Medication management at a distance deserves particular attention. Make sure they understand their medication, can manage repeat prescriptions, and know what to do if they miss doses or experience side effects. If medication is managed by a specialist, clarify how this will work when they are living away from home.

Part Four



Looking After Yourself



Managing Your Own Transition

The morning after you have dropped them at university, you might stand in their empty bedroom and feel something break inside you. This is not melodrama - it is a profound life transition that deserves recognition, support, and careful navigation. Yet society often expects you to simply celebrate their independence and move on. The reality is far more complex.

The Depth Of What You Are Experiencing

This transition represents multiple simultaneous losses. You are grieving the end of active daily parenting - those eighteen years of being needed for everything from midnight fevers to forgotten PE kits. You are mourning the simple presence of their energy in your home: the music from their room, their friends in the kitchen, even the arguments about tidying up. The house feels wrong - too quiet, too tidy, too still.

But it is more than physical absence. You are grieving the version of yourself who was primarily “Mum” or “Dad.” For nearly two decades, your identity has been fundamentally intertwined with active parenting. Your daily schedule, your worries, your joys, your purpose - all have revolved around your child. Now, suddenly, that central organising principle of your life has shifted, and you are left asking: “Who am I when I am not actively parenting?”

You might find yourself doing strange things. Setting their place at dinner from habit. Buying their favourite cereal then remembering they are not there to eat it. Hearing a song they love and reaching for your phone to tell them, then stopping because you do not want to intrude. Starting to tell a colleague about something they did, then realising the story is three months old because you do not have new daily stories anymore.

The Unique Grief Of The Empty Nest

Empty nest grief is what psychologists call “disenfranchised grief” - a loss that society does not fully recognise or support. When someone dies, there are rituals, sympathy cards, time off work. When your child leaves for university, you are expected to be proud and happy. People say “You must be so proud!” and “Think of all the freedom you’ll have!” when inside you are falling apart.

This grief is complicated because your child is still alive and well, so feeling bereaved seems wrong. It is tangled with pride and excitement for them. You know it is

“supposed” to happen, which does not make it easier. There is no clear endpoint - when do you stop grieving and start your “new life”? And it resurfaces unexpectedly: birthdays, holidays, or just an ordinary Tuesday afternoon.

If Your Young Person Is Neurodivergent

For parents of neurodivergent children, the empty nest experience has additional dimensions. You may have spent years in an intensive advocacy role - fighting for diagnosis, negotiating with schools, arranging support, managing meltdowns, providing daily scaffolding. This work became a significant part of your identity, and its sudden reduction can feel like a second loss on top of their physical absence.

You may also carry a specific kind of guilt: “Did I do enough? Are they ready? Have I taught them enough self-advocacy skills?” The worry may be more acute because you know, from experience, how quickly things can unravel when support is not in place. Learning to sit with this uncertainty, and trusting that your child can develop capabilities you have not yet seen, is some of the hardest work of this transition.

Physical And Emotional Symptoms You Might Experience

The stress of this transition can manifest in surprising ways.

Emotional symptoms may include waves of sadness that catch you off guard, anxiety about their wellbeing that feels disproportionate, irritability with your partner or remaining children, feeling lost or purposeless, unexpected anger (at them for leaving, at yourself for struggling), numbness or emotional flatness, and relief followed immediately by guilt about feeling relieved.

Physical symptoms may include sleep disruption, changes in appetite, fatigue that is not explained by activity, headaches or unexplained aches and pains, and restlessness or inability to settle to anything.

These are not signs of weakness or failure. They are normal responses to significant life change. Your body and mind are recalibrating to a fundamentally different reality.

The Complexity Of Modern Empty Nesting

Today’s empty nest experience differs from previous generations in important ways. You have likely been more involved in your child’s daily life than your parents were in yours. The pressure to be a “good parent” has intensified over recent decades, making the transition to non-active parenting even more jarring.

Additionally, you are dealing with a technology paradox (you can contact them instantly but should not), social media complexity (seeing glimpses of their life you are not part of), extended financial dependency (they are independent but still need financial support), and delayed life milestones (marriage and grandchildren may be decades away).

Navigating Relationship Changes

If you have a partner, this transition significantly impacts your relationship. You might discover you have become co-parents rather than partners, with little connecting you beyond your children. The silence at dinner might be deafening. Weekend plans might feel pointless. You might grieve differently, causing friction - one wanting to redecorate their room immediately, the other unable to change anything.

Conversely, you might rediscover each other in wonderful ways. Without the constant demands of active parenting, you can reconnect as individuals. Many couples report this as a relationship renaissance - if they can navigate the initial adjustment.

For single parents, the transition can be particularly intense. Your co-navigator is gone. The house is not just quieter; it is empty. The identity shift from active single parent to... what? The questions become more pressing, the silence louder.

Rediscovering Yourself

This transition, however painful, offers opportunity for rediscovery. Not the clichéd “finding yourself” of gap year students, but the deeper work of understanding who you are in this life phase.

Questions to explore: What did I put on hold for parenting that I might revisit? What aspects of my personality were dormant during active parenting? What relationships need attention now I have capacity? What brings me joy that is not connected to my children? What meaning and purpose drives me beyond parenting?

This is not about suddenly taking up salsa dancing (unless you want to). It is about genuine exploration of your identity, values, and desires in this new life chapter.

Practical Strategies For The Transition

Immediate coping (first few weeks): Let yourself feel whatever you are feeling without judgement. Do not make major decisions (redecorating their room can wait). Maintain some routines while letting others go. Connect with others going through the same transition. Write letters

to your child, even if you do not send them. Be gentle with yourself - this is hard.

Medium-term adjustment (first few months):

Consider counselling - this is significant enough to warrant support. Join groups or activities for your own enjoyment, not just to fill time. Gradually reclaim spaces in your home. Explore interests that were impractical during active parenting. Strengthen friendships that may have been neglected. Address relationship issues that were hidden by parenting.

Longer-term growth (six months onward): Develop new life rhythms that feel meaningful. Create new family traditions that work with adult children. Invest in your own development - career, education, hobbies. Build an identity that includes but is not limited to being a parent. Consider how you want to use this life phase. Embrace the evolution of your relationship with your child.



Resources For Parents

Understanding Your Experience

The empty nest transition deserves the same support as any major life change. You are not being dramatic, weak, or a “helicopter parent” for struggling. You are human, experiencing one of life’s significant transitions.

Professional Support Services

Many therapists specialise in life transitions and empty nest adjustment. Couples counselling can help navigate relationship changes. Group therapy with other empty nest parents provides community. Online therapy platforms offer convenience and privacy.

To search for support, try:

BACP (British Association for Counselling and Psychotherapy):

www.bacp.co.uk

Psychology Today UK: www.psychologytoday.com/gb

Relate (relationship counselling): www.relate.org.uk

Telephone Support Lines

Family Lives Helpline: 0808 800 2222 - Free, confidential support for any aspect of parenting, including empty nest.

Young Minds Parents Helpline: 0808 802 5544 (Mon-Fri) - Support for parents concerned about their child’s mental health.

Samaritans: 116 123 (24/7) - For when emotions feel overwhelming.

Mind Infoline: 0300 123 3393 (Mon-Fri 9am-6pm) - Information and support for mental health concerns.

Online Communities And Forums:

The Student Room - Parents' Forum (thestudentroom.co.uk) - UK-specific university parent community.

Mumsnet - Higher Education Board - Active, supportive community of UK parents.

University-specific parent Facebook groups - Search “[University name] Parents” on Facebook.

University Resources For Parents

Some universities recognise parent needs and offer parent orientation programmes, parent/family offices or liaisons, parent newsletters with tips and updates, parent Facebook groups or forums, family weekend events, webinars on supporting student mental health, and clear protocols for emergency contact. Do not hesitate to contact your child's university student services for guidance on supporting them.

Books For Deeper Understanding

“The Empty Nest: How to Survive and Stay Close to Your Adult Child” by Celia Dodd - UK-focused, practical and emotionally intelligent.

“Letting Go: A Parents' Guide to Understanding the College Years” by Karen Coburn & Madge Treeger - Comprehensive guide through all university years.

“How to Cope When Your Child Can't” by Roz Shafran & Ursula Saunders - For parents supporting children with mental health challenges.

“Untangled” by Lisa Damour - Understanding your daughter's development (also excellent for sons).

“Option B” by Sheryl Sandberg & Adam Grant - Excellent on resilience through life transitions.

“Unmasking Autism” by Devon Price - Helpful if your child is newly diagnosed or exploring neurodivergence.

Activities And Groups For Your Wellbeing

University of the Third Age (U3A): Learning and activities for those not in full-time work.

WI, Rotary, Lions Clubs: Community involvement and purpose.

Volunteer opportunities: Using your skills for causes you care about.

Adult education courses: That degree you always wanted? That skill you wished to learn?

Sports and fitness groups: Physical activity helps emotional regulation.

Book clubs, craft groups, walking groups: Low-pressure social connection.

When To Seek Immediate Help

If you experience persistent thoughts of self-harm, inability to function in daily life after several weeks, substance use to cope with emotions, relationship breakdown, or severe anxiety or depression, contact your GP immediately or call 111 for mental health support.

Remember: seeking support is not failure - it is wisdom. You have supported your child through countless transitions. Now it is time to support yourself through yours.

Part Five



Practical Tools



How To Use The Worksheets

The following worksheets are designed to help you reflect on and navigate this transition. They are not assessments or obligations - use them in whatever way serves you. Some might be most helpful in the weeks before your child leaves. Others are designed for regular use throughout the year. Some you might want to complete with your partner, a friend, or a counsellor.

You do not need to complete all worksheets or use them in order. Choose what feels relevant to your current situation. If a worksheet does not resonate, skip it. These are tools for your benefit.



Parent Worksheets

Worksheet 1: Communication Planning

Part A: Agreeing Contact Patterns

Communication Method	Agreed Frequency	Best Times	Boundaries / Notes
<i>Phone Calls</i>			
<i>Video Calls</i>			
<i>Messaging / Texts</i>			
<i>Social Media Interaction</i>			
<i>Visits Home</i>			
<i>Your Visits to University</i>			

Part B: What I Need vs What They Need**Part C: Communication That Works**

Area	What I Need (as a parent)	What They Need (as a student)	How We Can Meet in the Middle
<i>Frequency of contact</i>			
<i>Level of detail about their life</i>			
<i>Reassurance about their safety</i>			
<i>Involvement in decisions</i>			
<i>Financial transparency</i>			

Instead of This...	Try This...	Why It Works
“Are you okay?” (implies you expect them not to be)	“Thinking of you” or “What’s been good this week?”	Opens conversation without pressure
“You never call me”	“I love our chats. When works best for you this week?”	Frames contact positively
“Have you been to lectures?”	“What’s been interesting in your course?”	Shows interest without surveillance
Immediately offering solutions	“That sounds tough. What do you think your options are?”	Supports their problem-solving

Worksheet 2: Boundary Negotiation

This worksheet can be completed with your child, or used for your own reflection.

Part A: Financial Boundaries

Question	Our Agreement
<i>What will I/we fund?</i>	
<i>What will they cover themselves?</i>	
<i>Is financial support conditional on anything? (Be honest)</i>	
<i>How will we handle unexpected expenses?</i>	
<i>Is there an emergency fund? How is it accessed?</i>	
<i>How much spending transparency is expected?</i>	
<i>DSA application status (if applicable)</i>	

Part B: Academic Boundaries

Question	Our Agreement
<i>Will I have access to grades?</i>	
<i>What is my role if they struggle academically?</i>	
<i>Will I be involved in course or module choices?</i>	
<i>What if they want to change course or leave?</i>	
<i>How will we discuss AI tools and academic integrity?</i>	

Part C: Independence Boundaries

Area	They Decide Independently	We Discuss Together	I Need To Be Consulted
<i>Daily routine</i>			
<i>Social life and friendships</i>			
<i>Romantic relationships</i>			
<i>Health decisions</i>			
<i>Career and work experience</i>			
<i>Summer plans</i>			
<i>Major financial decisions</i>			

Worksheet 3: Crisis Contacts And Response Plan

Part A: Key Contacts

Contact Name	Phone Number	When To Use
<i>Emergency Services</i>	999	Immediate danger
<i>Samaritans</i>	116 123	Need to talk, 24/7
<i>Young Minds Parents Helpline</i>	0808 802 5544	Worried about child's mental health
<i>PAPYRUS HOPELINE 247</i>	0800 068 4141	Under 35, suicidal thoughts
<i>Shout</i>	Text SHOUT to 85258	24/7 text support
<i>Child's university wellbeing service</i>		
<i>Child's university security</i>		
<i>Child's university GP</i>		
<i>Child's flat mate or close friend at uni</i>		
<i>Family GP at home</i>		
<i>My own support person</i>		

Part B: What Concerns Me and My Response Plan

My Specific Worry	What Would Trigger Me To Act	What I Would Do First	Who I Would Contact

Part C: If My Child Is in Crisis

Step	Action	Notes
1	<i>Stay calm - my anxiety will not help them</i>	
2	<i>Listen without judgement</i>	
3	<i>Ask directly about safety and suicidal thoughts</i>	
4	<i>Connect them with professional support</i>	
5	<i>Contact university services if they cannot</i>	
6	<i>Consider visiting if seriously worried</i>	
7	<i>Look after my own emotional response afterwards</i>	

Worksheet 4: Weekly Self-Care Check-In

Week Beginning: _____

Area	This Week (1-10)	What Helped	What Was Hard	What I Need Next Week
<i>Mood</i>				
<i>Sleep</i>				
<i>Energy</i>				
<i>Social Connection</i>				
<i>Purpose / Meaning</i>				
<i>Relationship with Partner (if applicable)</i>				
<i>Worry Level About My Child</i>				

Part A: How Am I Really Doing?Part B: Weekly Reflection

Question	My Answer
<i>What did I do for myself this week?</i>	
<i>Did I contact my child? How did it go?</i>	
<i>What emotions came up unexpectedly?</i>	
<i>Did I seek support? From whom?</i>	
<i>What am I looking forward to?</i>	
<i>What do I need to let go of this week?</i>	

Worksheet 5: Relationship Navigation

For reflecting on how this transition is affecting your key relationships.

Part A: Relationship Impact Assessment

Relationship	How This Transition Is Affecting It	What They Might Need From Me	What I Need From Them	Action To Take
<i>Partner / Spouse</i>				
<i>Other Children at Home</i>				
<i>The Child at University</i>				
<i>My Own Parents</i>				
<i>Close Friends</i>				
<i>Work Colleagues</i>				

Part B: Partner Conversation Starters (if applicable)

Topic	Questions To Explore Together
<i>How are we each coping?</i>	
<i>What do we miss most?</i>	
<i>How has our relationship changed?</i>	
<i>What do we want to do with this time?</i>	
<i>Are we grieving differently? How can we respect that?</i>	
<i>What new traditions or routines could we create?</i>	

Worksheet 6: Your Own Transition Timeline

Mapping your emotional journey through your child's first year.

Part A: Emotional Journey Map

Time Period	Expected / Actual Feelings	What Helped	What I Wish I Had Known	Advice For My Future Self
<i>Before They Left</i>				
<i>First Week</i>				
<i>Weeks 2-4</i>				
<i>First Month</i>				
<i>Months 2-3</i>				
<i>End of First Term</i>				
<i>Their First Visit Home</i>				
<i>Start of Second Term</i>				
<i>End of First Year</i>				

Part B: My Warning Signs and Wellness Indicators

Signs I Am Struggling	Signs I Am Coping Well	My Action Plan When Struggling

Worksheet 7: Values And Identity Exploration

Who are you beyond “parent”?

Part A: Identity Audit

Identity / Role	How Important Before University (1-10)	How Important Now (1-10)	How Satisfied (1-10)	What I Want To Develop
<i>Parent</i>				
<i>Partner</i>				
<i>Friend</i>				
<i>Professional / Career</i>				
<i>Learner</i>				
<i>Creative Person</i>				
<i>Community Member</i>				
<i>Person With Hobbies / Interests</i>				
<i>[Your own:]</i>				

Part B: Rediscovery Questions

Question	My Honest Answer
What did I put on hold for parenting?	
What have I always wanted to try?	
What brings me energy (not just fills time)?	
Who have I lost touch with that I would like to reconnect with?	
If I had a completely free Saturday, what would I choose to do?	
What would I want my life to look like in one year?	
What is one small step I could take this week?	

Part Six



Conclusion And References



Your Journey Forward

Acknowledging Your Experience

If you have read this far, you are taking your own transition seriously. That matters. The empty nest experience is not a footnote to your child's university story - it is your own significant life chapter, and it deserves the same care and attention you have given to every other major transition you have navigated.

The Long View

This transition reshapes your relationship fundamentally. The child who left for university will not return in quite the same way - instead, an emerging adult will visit, bringing new perspectives, experiences, and independence. This is not loss but transformation.

Your relationship can become richer: moving from vertical (parent-down) to horizontal (adult-to-adult), from protection to mutual support, from teaching to learning from each other. This evolution takes time, involves mistakes, and requires grieving what was while embracing what is becoming.

What To Hold Onto

Their struggles do not reflect your parenting. Stepping back is not abandonment. Your emotions about this transition are valid. They still need you, just differently. This adjustment is temporary; the relationship continues.

The university years challenge both generations, but families who navigate them thoughtfully often emerge with stronger, more authentic connections. Trust the foundation you have built, respect the independence they are building, and remain available as their safe harbour in the storms of young adulthood.

Final Words

I hope this guide is useful to you. It has been written with genuine care for what you are going through, because I believe that supporting parents through this transition is just as important as supporting students. The challenges you face are real, your feelings are valid, and you deserve support.

However, please do not use this guide as a substitute for seeking support in real life if you need to. Your GP, a counsellor, or one of the helplines listed in this guide can offer personalised support that no written resource can replace.

Take it one day at a time. Be kind to yourself. Ask for help when you need it. And remember - you have done a remarkable job getting them this far.



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